TELLING TALES

BOOKS

***Indrani Mukerjea** presents her side of the story in this no-holds-barred (well, almost) memoir*

Murder-accused Indrani Mukerjea's life story makes for unpleasant reading, but there are at least three things to admire.

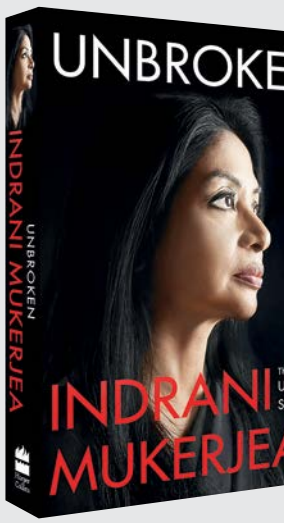
True grit, for one. The daughter whose murder Mukerjea is accused of was the result of being raped as a teenager by her own father. A male friend offers to legitimise the birth while offering to marry her. A year later, she has a son by him, but remains unmarried. She does well at school and college, abandons the friend, and at barely 19, cedes custody of both children to her parents. She goes to Kolkata, completes her degree, begins her working life with the Diners Club and soon marries Sanjeev Khanna, a businessman. Has a daughter by him, grows disenchanted and moves to Mumbai. There she meets Peter Mukerjea, eventually marries him and they fly up the corporate totem pole together.

Second, there's her steely disregard for society's double standards. Throughout this narrative, wherever any other young woman would have been crushed beyond repair, Mukerjea raises her head and pushes past "what will people say" to reach the blessed freedom of "I don't care". She talks openly about the treacheries she has faced, from parents, lovers, husbands and her children. But even as she describes her tears, her rage and extreme isolation, she presents herself as a warrior, not a victim.

Third, her description of six and a half years in prison is startlingly clear-eyed and positive. The humiliation of being stripped naked at the time of entering jail and the loss of such basic amenities as a flush toilet are described alongside the camaraderie and the plain but apparently healthy food. The prison authorities are not vilified, and neither is the justice system, however snail-paced.

It should come as no surprise that almost nothing is said about the murder that Mukerjea is accused of. She's out on bail and not exonerated, so there are limits placed on what she can reveal about the

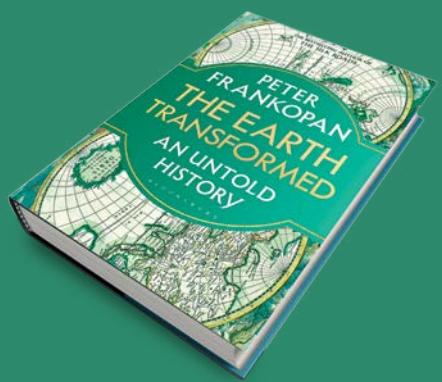
UNBROKEN
The Untold Story
by Indrani Mukerjea
HARPERCOLLINS
₹599; 400 pages



BOOKS

WEATHERING THE STORM

Peter Frankopan's book brings a genuinely global perspective to climate change and how it has shaped the course of world history



THE EARTH TRANSFORMED
An Untold History
by Peter Frankopan
BLOOMSBURY
₹850; 704 pages

To be alive in the 21st century is to inhabit a paradox. Never before have we been able to alter our environment so thoroughly. Airconditioning, internet connectivity, speedy travel, and products from around the globe have made the world our oyster. Yet, that oyster is agitated by turbulent currents, cracked open by floods, droughts, fires and plagues that seem to be visited upon us by vengeful gods. The technical instruments we control and the political and economic institutions we have built seem to be failing. And much of the crisis is our own fault.

Peter Frankopan tells us that none of this is new. The scale of the crisis may now be planetary but, over millennia, many civilisations that sought to conquer their environment confronted a similar threat of collapse. Whether mighty empires melted away or survived depended on how they responded to